SECTION 1

Who Is the Thief?

Four cases · owner, loss, law

Most people can picture a thief: someone who takes what belongs to another, without permission. The thief is usually the easiest person in the story to identify. The label seems to follow from the act. This section tests that idea through four cases.

Each case is checked against three conditions: an owner, a loss, and a law that names the taking as a crime. In an ordinary theft, all three are present, and so is the thief. Each case that follows keeps the taking in plain sight and changes something else.

Two women take the same goods from the same counter, but only one is called a thief. An outlaw robs travellers at knifepoint, and centuries of retelling turn him into a hero. A palace is looted, and its treasures pass through so many lawful hands that no single person seems to have taken them.

The taking stays visible throughout. What changes is who the taker is, who the victim is, where the goods end up, and how much time has passed. The label ‘thief’ turns out to depend on more than the act.

Audio guide · Section 1
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